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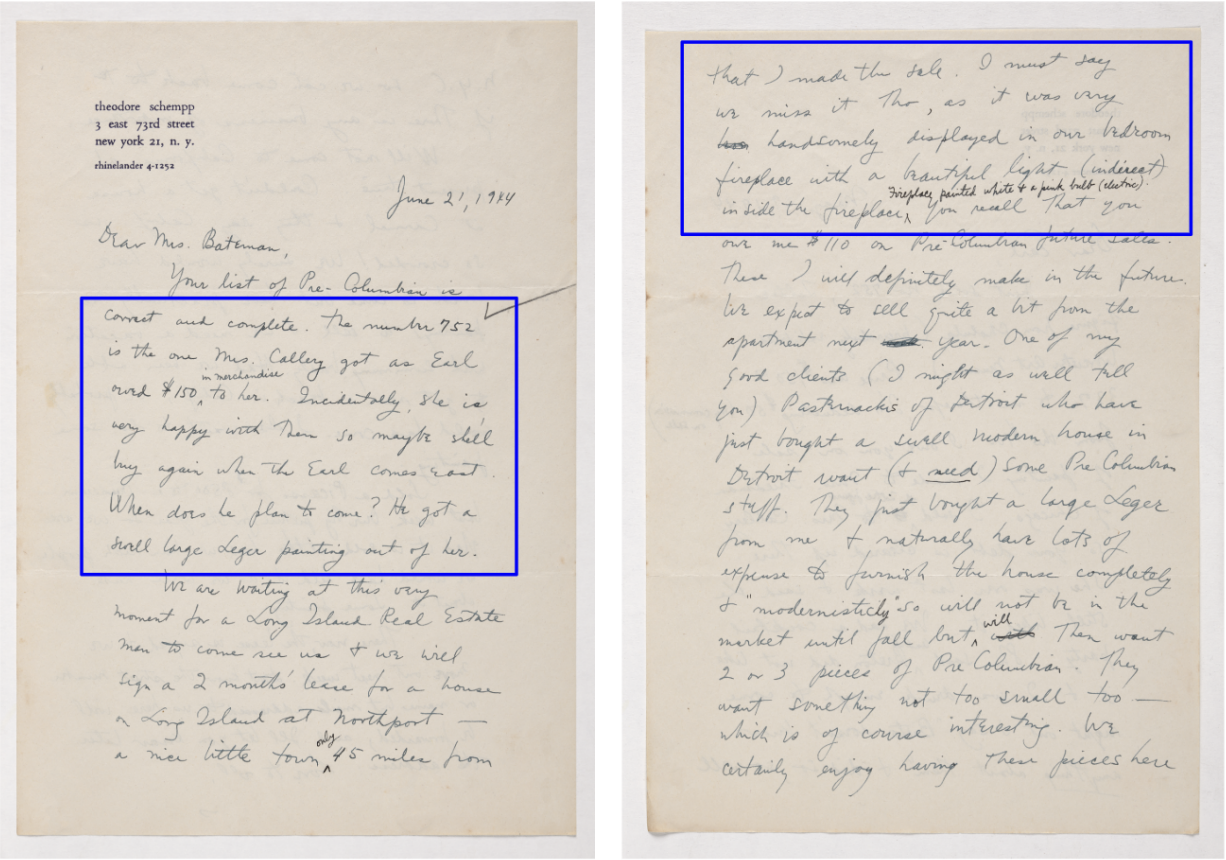
A Pre-Hispanic Man and an Avant-Garde Woman: Illicit Trysts in the Mid-Century Art Market

Kylie G. King

Writing from New York in 1944, the art dealer Theodore Schempp reported to Delfina Bateman, secretary of the Stendahl Art Galleries (SAG) in Los Angeles, that the modernist sculptor and collector Mary Callery had acquired a “Toltec figure” from Earl Stendahl’s pre-Hispanic inventory (fig. 1a) (Schempp to Bateman, 21 Jun. 1944, SAGR, b99f6).[1] In the same note, he remarked that Stendahl had also “got a swell large Leger [*sic*] out of her.” While a pre-Hispanic figurine and a modernist painting might seem to inhabit entirely separate aesthetic and geographic worlds, their convergence in New York in 1944 was no coincidence; rather, it reflected structural conditions of the twentieth-century art market, in which categories traditionally treated by scholarship as discrete—separating ancient from modern, fine art from artifact—were, in fact, deeply entangled. Although scholarship has examined avant-garde artists’ and collectors’ engagement with pre-Columbian art (see, for example, Moure Cecchini 2021; Nelson et al. 2020; Biro 2015; Fee 2011; Coe 1990), the intersection of the markets for modern European and the ancient American art and the interconnected networks of art-market actors, remains comparatively understudied.

[1] The sale actually took place several weeks earlier (Schempp to Earl Stendahl, 29 May 1944, SAGR, b99f6). Callery appears three times in the Stendahl Inventory Books. In addition to Inv. No. 752, which was listed at $175, the other entries include: Inv. No. 703, “Frog Yoke - Totonac,” priced at $1000 and Inv. No. 1011, “[Gold] Frog Panama,” for $200. Although the transaction dates were not annotated, all three entries are recorded in the earliest book, which documents pre-Hispanic stock that likely entered the Gallery’s inventory from the mid-1930s (Inventory Book, SAGR, b91f6). This is corroborated by a 1941 letter to anthropologist and curator George Clapp Vaillant in which Standahl declared, “You will marvel at the great number of good things I have been able to gather together in the past six years” (Earl Stendahl to George Vaillant, SAGR, b1f2).



theodore schempp
3 east 73rd street
new york 21, n. y.
rhinelander 4-1252

June 21, 1944

Dear Mrs. Bateman,

Your list of Pre-Columbian is correct and complete. The number 752 is the one Mrs. Calley got as Earl owed $150 in merchandise to her. Incidentally, she is very happy with them so maybe she'll buy again when the Earl comes east. When does he plan to come? He got a small large Leger painting out of her.

We are waiting at this very moment for a Long Island Real Estate man to come see us & we will sign a 2 months' lease for a house on Long Island at Northport — a nice little town only 45 miles from

that I made the sale. I must say we miss it tho, as it was very handsomely displayed in our bedroom fireplace with a beautiful light (indirect) inside the fireplace. Fireplace painted white & a pink bulb (electric). You recall that you owe me $110 on Pre-Columbian pieces. These I will definitely make in the future. We expect to sell quite a bit from the apartment next year. One of my good clients (I might as well tell you) Pastrnacks of Detroit who have just bought a swell modern house in Detroit want (& need) some Pre Columbian stuff. They just bought a large Leger from me & naturally have lots of expense to furnish the house completely & "modernistically" so will not be in the market until fall but will then want 2 or 3 pieces of Pre Columbian. They want something not too small too — which is of course interesting. We certainly enjoy having these pieces here

Fig. 1a-b. Letter from Theodore Schempp to Delfina Bateman (Earl Stendahl's secretary/accountant) dated Jun. 21, 1944 [page 1]; Letter from Theodore Schempp to Earl Stendahl dated May 29, 1944 [page 2]. Stendahl Art Galleries Archive. Getty Research Institute, Los Angeles (2017.M.38), Gift of April and Ronald Dammann.

Stendahl, who built his profile as a dealer selling paintings and sculpture from his Los Angeles café and galleries early in the twentieth century, incorporated pre-Hispanic, material into his inventory in the mid-1930s, when he started routinely presenting pre-Hispanic and modern artworks side-by-side, later expanding to include African, Oceanic, Native American, Indian, Cambodian, and Mediterranean materials in his stable. The intersection of the ancient figurine and the avant-garde painting was, therefore, symptomatic of an entangled and global sphere in which juxtaposition became commercial strategy, as well as aesthetic and intellectual methodology.

Far from hinting at two unrelated transactions, then, Schempp’s comment suggests a dynamic in which an ancient American clay sculpture and a modernist canvas intersected within the same series of commercial exchanges. Indeed, Stendahl’s records contain many examples of such transactions, like when he traded New York-based dealer Pierre Matisse a “small [Henri]

Matiess [*sic*] for a Tarascan piece,” which he planned to onsell to a West Coast collector (Earl Stendahl to Alfred Stendahl, 6 Dec. 1949, SAGR, b106f1).

Worlds Converge

Such entanglements were already evident in the early twentieth century. In Paris, for example, the Brummer Galleries displayed objects from Africa, the Americas, Asia, medieval Europe, the ancient Mediterranean, and Oceania alongside modern works (Biro 2015, 1, 10; Hollevoet-Force 2018; Jones 2010, 55–7). In 1914—one year after the Armory Show introduced modern art to America—they opened a New York branch, from which they presented objects in a diversity of shapes, dates, and origins to American audiences (Biro 2015, 2-3; Hollevoet-Force 2018; see also BGR, 1890–1996). The following year, Mexican dealer Marius de Zayas opened his Modern Gallery on Fifth Avenue, which integrated African art throughout the gallery spaces, and exhibited pre-Hispanic works alongside Cubist paintings in his 1916 *Exhibition of Mexican Pre-Conquest Art—Exhibition of Paintings by Diego Rivera* (Moure Cecchini 2021, 251–53; Fee 2011, 14).

Institutional attitudes, however, lagged behind those of these avant-garde gallerists: in 1914, the Metropolitan Museum of Art separated its pre-Hispanic holdings from the rest of its collections, sending them to the American Museum of Natural History (Pillsbury 2024, 244–51; Turner, et al. 2026, 93). This division demonstrates that major art-collecting institutions still considered these objects as artifacts, rather than as works of art. An institutional shift came in 1933, when the Museum of Modern Art opened *American Sources of Modern Art*, casting 233 pre-Hispanic objects as spiritual precursors to the works of American modernists (MoMA 1933). Though largely fictive, the genealogies proposed by the museum curators helped pave the way for the broader appreciation—and appropriation—of pre-Hispanic material culture.

Over the following years, pre-Hispanic works began to enter the homes of fashionable American collectors, as epitomized by *Vogue* in 1945, when pre-Hispanic art appeared as a complement to Modern works in a spread entitled “Great Art… in Four California Houses” (Dapprich 1945). Featuring the homes of Hollywood actors Charles Laughton and Edward G. Robinson and collectors Ruth Maitland and Louise and Walter Arensberg, the article evidences that, by mid-century, pre-Hispanic objects had been absorbed into the aesthetic, commercial, and domestic circuit of the fashionable élite.

Fig. 2. The Stendahl home gallery, 7055 Hillside Avenue, dining room, ca. 1940s. Stendahl Art Galleries Archive. Getty Research Institute, Los Angeles (2017.M.38), Gift of April and Ronald Dammann. © J. Paul Getty Trust. © Successió Miró / Artists Rights Society (ARS), New York / ADAGP, Paris 2026.

By this time, the Arensbergs were not only Stendahl’s principal clients for pre-Hispanic art,[2] but also his next-door neighbors (Dammann 2011, 164; Turner et al. 2026, 75–77), and in 1945 Stendahl followed their avant-garde aesthetic style, reimagining his Hollywood Hills home gallery as a white-walled domestic space that would appeal to such sensibilities, where pre-Hispanic and avant-garde works could be seen—and acquired—together (fig. 2) (SAGR, b108f4). Stendahl and other dealers thus marketed pre-Hispanic objects as chic and complementary additions to modern interiors and collections (Turner et al. 2026, 122–23; O’Neil

[2] The Inventory Books show that the Arensbergs were among SAG’s most prolific and profitable clients, ranking fourth in terms of number of objects purchased (close to 160), and acquiring one of the most expensive items to have ever entered Stendahl stock—Inv. No. 1627, Aztec Calendar Stone (Inventory Books, SAGR, b91f6 and b97)—for $20,000, which was, as Ellen Hoobler has written, “almost certainly the highest price they paid for any single work in their collection at any time” (Hoobler 2020, 386).

and Miller 2023, 9), a strategy that collapsed temporal distance in the service of contemporary taste.

A Propitious Partnership

In the mid-1930s, Schempp relocated from New York to Paris, establishing himself on the Left Bank as a dealer of modern paintings. His move coincided with the rise of National Socialism and the increasing dispersal of private and public collections, often by coercion and dispossession. This instability created opportunities for dealers operating within the international art market: Schempp—and, by extension, his associates, like Stendahl—positioned themselves within a propitious, yet ethically fraught, landscape.

Fig. 3. Earl Stendahl, Theodore Schempp, and Alma May Cook in Santa Barbara, ca. 1940. Stendahl Art Galleries Archive. Getty Research Institute, Los Angeles (2017.M.38), Gift of April and Ronald Dammann.

Although the precise circumstances of their acquaintance remain unclear, it is plausible that Schempp and Stendahl met through shared commercial interests in both modernist paintings and pre-Hispanic objects. Indeed, correspondence preserved in both the SAG records and the Arensberg Archive places the two dealers within a transactional network of “cross

cultural” collectors in the US;[3] by around 1935, Schempp was dealing in modern artworks with the Arensbergs (Schempp to Louise Arensberg, 23 May 1935, in WLAA, box 28, folder 25), and in 1937 Stendahl purchased from Schempp a sketch by Marcel Duchamp, which he subsequently sold to the Arensbergs (Sawelson-Gorse 1991, 41–42, n.6).

The SAG records include letters from Schempp to Stendahl concerning sales of modern European paintings to collectors like the Arensbergs and Edward G. Robinson as early as 1935 (see, for example, Schempp to Earl Stendahl, 6 Nov. 1935, SAGR, b99f7). Hoobler suggests that Schempp and the Arensbergs might have initially connected through the Brummer Gallery in New York, of which the couple were longstanding clients and to which Schempp was selling pre-Hispanic art by the mid-1930s (Hoobler 2020, 365). Coe likewise linked the Arensberg–Stendahl relationship to the modern art inventory of the latter (Coe 1990, 279–80). Building on this, I believe that Schempp might have played a fundamental role in introducing Stendahl to the pre-Hispanic art trade via modern art: returning from a joint family trip to Taxco in early 1936, Stendahl wrote to Schempp, “I arrived home last Monday and immediately called Arensberg […] He is very much interested [in a “stone idol”] and I think we can do business with him right off the bat [...]. I sold him the large Picabia and also have been commissioned to buy another painting for him” (Stendahl to Schempp, 1 Feb. 1936, SAGR, b99f8; Stendahl to Schempp 3 Mar. 1936, SAGR, b99f8; see also note 1 herein).

Schempp returned to the US during the occupation of Paris, but he nonetheless continued to source modern paintings from France and channel them to the other side of the Atlantic. While it remains unclear whether he and Stendahl directly handled works that had been expropriated, looted, or transferred under coercion, Schempp did attend and write to Stendahl about the 1939 Nazi-organized auction “Gemälde und Plastiken moderner Meister aus Deutschen Museen" at the Galerie Fischer, Lucerne (Schempp to Earl Stendahl, 16 Jul. 1939, SAGR, b99f5). The broader implications of sales under duress and forced emigration should also be considered here, particularly in relation to US-based art dealers sourcing modern paintings from refugees and individuals in distress. In a letter of late-1941, Schempp mentions a “Degas we got from Fougner” (Schempp to Earl Stendahl, 1 Dec. 1941, SAGR, b99f5)—likely

[3] Michael Coe observed that this phenomenon emerged among the European avant-garde (Coe 1990, 272). Humorously, Schempp reported that Callery had remarked that surrealist poet André Breton did not like the “Toltec figure” that she was interested in, to which the dealer drunkenly retorted “Breton doesn’t know anything about them!,” successfully convincing her to buy the object nonetheless (Schempp to Earl Stendahl, 29 May 1944, SAGR, b99f6). While he primarily focused on other regions, Breton did own some objects from Latin America (see O'Hanlan 2020, esp. 221, fig. 26; Fee 2011, 13).

referring to the interior designer Leni Michels-Fougner, who had fled Berlin for New York during WWII and subsequently sustained herself with the sales of artworks she had managed to bring with her (Kessemeier 2023).

As already mentioned, the correspondence suggests that Schempp might have been directly involved in Stendahl’s early forays into the pre-Hispanic art market. In a 1936 letter, accompanied by a check for $175 representing Schempp’s share for the sale of a “stone idol” that Earl had placed with Walter Arensberg, Stendahl noted that he had followed Schempp’s advice on pricing jade objects (Stendahl to Schempp, 5 Mar. 1936, SAGR, b99f8). Moreover, Stendahl’s closing request, “As soon as you find anything, have photographs sent to me immediately,” signals his intention to continue growing his inventory of paintings and pre-Hispanic objects with Schempp’s help. These transactions therefore underscore the intermingling of their commercial activities, and mark the beginning of a sustained partnership documented across multiple Inventory Book annotations (including trades of pre-Hispanic for modern European artworks) and dozens of letters spanning the 1930s through the 1960s.

This letter also indicates that Schempp and Stendahl deliberately paired modern and Mesoamerican art in order to appeal to mid-century collectors. Far from whimsy, this was strategy, and it proved effective![4] In an earlier letter to Stendahl (fig. 1b), several weeks before notifying Delfina Bateman of the sale of the “Toltec figure,” Schempp described how he had staged the object in his apartment while it awaited sale: positioned under a pink electric light bulb within a white-painted fireplace (Schempp to Earl Stendahl, 21 Jun. 1944, SAGR, b99f6). His careful attention to display—situating the sculpture in an electrified, white cube-like setting—heightened its appeal to a collector attuned to the aesthetics of modernity, recontextualizing and reframing an ancient object as distinctly *modern*.

Assigned the Stendahl inventory number 752, the figurine’s “Toltec” attribution is likely erroneous. Although a photograph of this specific object has yet to be located in the archive, it was more plausibly a West Mexican shaft tomb figurine (Andrew Turner and Michael Mathiowetz, pers. comm., 12 May 2025), comparable to inventory numbers 749 and 750, which appear on the same inventory book page as 752, and which were purchased by none other than the Arensbergs (figs. 4a-b) (Inventory Book, SAGR, b91f6).

[4] The header of SAG branded stationary came to routinely feature the words “pre-Columbian” and “Modern Paintings” (Earl Stendahl to Alfred Stendahl, 7 Nov. [1956], SAGR, b105f8).

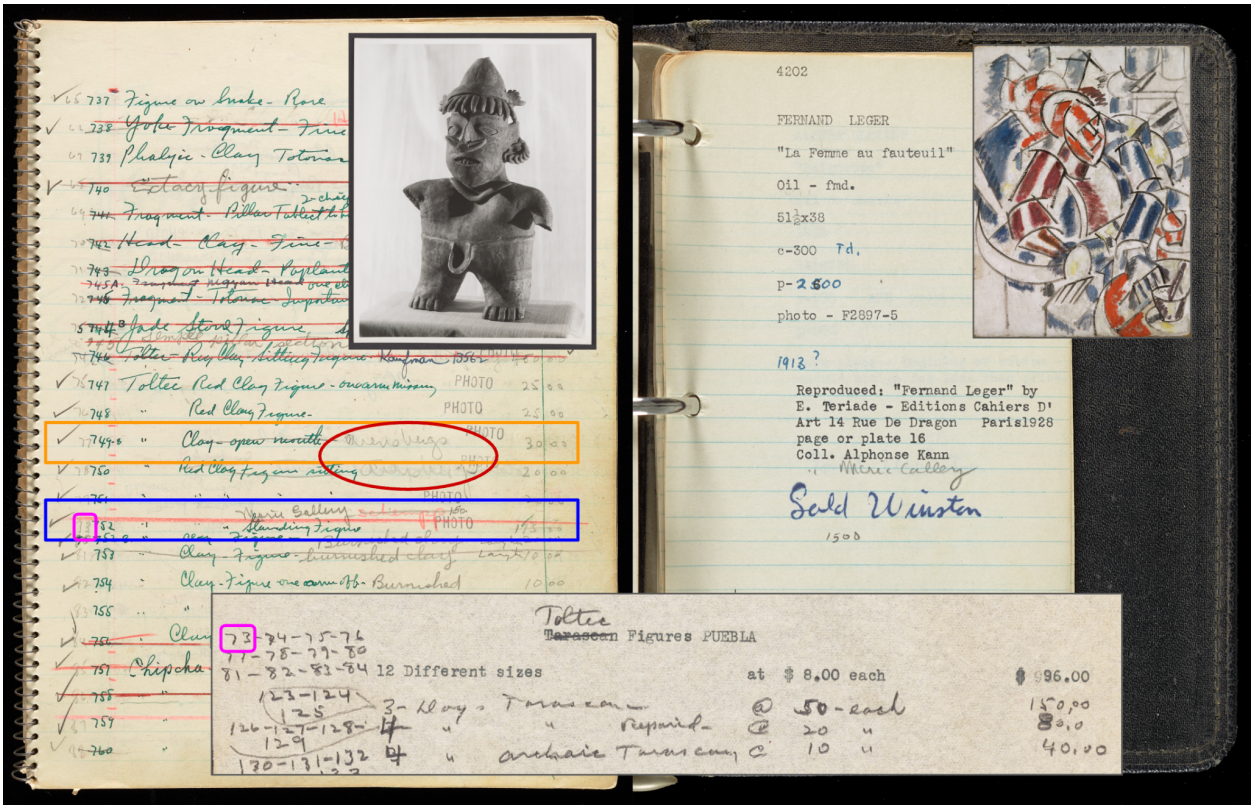


Fig. 4a-e. a. Clockwise from left: Stendahl Art Galleries Inventory Book, Inv. No.s 737–760. Stendahl Art Galleries Archive. Getty Research Institute, Los Angeles (2017.M.38), Gift of April and Ronald Dammann. © J. Paul Getty Trust.; **b.** Photograph of red clay man figurine owned by Walter and Louise Arensberg. Photo credit: Floyd Faxon. AA, 1905–1957. Duchamp Research Portal. WLA_B058_F061_001. Courtesy of the Philadelphia Museum of Art; **c.** Fernand Léger "La Femme au fauteuil" entry [Inv. No. 4202]. Stendahl Art Galleries Notebook: Artists. Stendahl Art Galleries Archive. Getty Research Institute, Los Angeles (2017.M.38), Gift of April and Ronald Dammann. © J. Paul Getty Trust.; **d.** Fernand Léger, *La femme au fauteuil*, 1913. Oil on canvas, 130.5 x 97.5 cm, Fondation Beyeler, Riehen/Basel, Beyeler Collection. Photo credit: Cantz Medienmanagement, Ostfildern. © 2026 Artists Rights Society (ARS), New York; **e.** Price list (detail). Guillermo Echániz and Earl Stendahl, [first half of 1941], Stendahl Art Galleries Archive. Getty Research Institute, Los Angeles (2017.M.38), Gift of April and Ronald Dammann.

Building on the exchange first noted in Schempp’s letter to Bateman (fig. 1a), the archival record suggests even deeper entanglements, linking the ancient American sculpture and the European modernist painting while exposing provenance gaps for both. Stendahl’s entry (fig. 4c) (Inv. No. 4202, Stendahl Art Galleries Notebook: Artists, SAGR, b93) for Fernand Léger’s *La femme au fauteuil* (1913) (fig. 4d) bears the annotation “Td,” Stendahl’s shorthand for *trade*, suggesting that the painting entered his stock not through purchase, but as part of a negotiated artwork exchange—the type of transaction that materially binds ancient American sculpture to European modernism within the same economies of artistry and value. Léger himself acquired a similar figurine from Stendahl: Inv. No. 1121, “Tarascan Figure - Narayit as

“Traded to Leger; Leger [*sic*]” (Inventory Book, SAGR, b91f6). This raises the possibility that Léger exchanged one of his own works for a pre-Hispanic object: a reciprocal transaction that nonetheless reflects the dynamics underpinning the mid-century market, in which Indigenous cultural objects—often looted or illicitly excavated—were transformed into commodities for appropriation, circulation, and exchange on the international art market.

The inventory record for *La femme au fauteuil* offers other tantalizing provenance information: it had previously belonged to the distinguished collector Alphonse Kann, who, like the Arensbergs, was a client of Brummer Galleries (Biro 2015, 13) and cultivated a celebrated and eclectic collection of diverse artworks—including Mesoamerican objects and modern paintings—that he displayed in his domestic space (Felliciano 1997, 110–111).[5] Kann fled Paris in 1938, and in October 1940 his un-inventoried collection was looted by the Nazis (Felliciano 1997, 201).[6] Our Léger, which Kann acquired from Parisian dealer Daniel-Henry Kahnweiler (Solomon R. Guggenheim Museum 1973, 120), was in Kann’s collection by 1928 (Tériade 1928, 16). By February 1939, however, the painting was in Callery’s possession, when she loaned it to an exhibition in Amsterdam (Stedelijk Museum 1939, cat. 39)—meaning that it left Kann’s hands before the looting occurred through a transaction that documentation has yet to clarify. It remains unclear, therefore, when and why Kann parted with the painting, through whom it subsequently passed, or under what circumstances it was transferred. The painting, in other words, carries its own unresolved gap at the point of acquisition preceding its move to the US—one that, as we shall see, echoes a comparable gap in the figurine’s history.

Callery, who had lived and worked in Paris before returning to the US in July 1940, just weeks after the German occupation of the city, was represented by the dealer Curt Valentin, with whom she sometimes worked to procure and sell modern art (see, for example, Callery to Valentin, 28 July 1935 and Valentin to Callery, 12 Nov. 1938. CVP, III.A.57. MoMA Archives, in which they discuss the sale of artworks by Picasso, Matisse, and Braque). Valentin, head of the Buchholz Gallery in New York—a conduit for Nazi-confiscated art during WWII (Reichskammer

[5] Kann’s avant-garde collecting is evidenced by his loan of Cat. No. 45: “Le dieu Quetzalcoatl, sous la forme du serpent emplumé, enroulé. Serpentine sculptée” to the 1928 exhibition on ancient American art (Musée des Arts Décoratifs 1928, 5; Mary Miller, pers. comm., 22 July 2026). Other avant-garde lenders to this exhibition include, but are not limited to, André Breton and photographer Paul Haviland. For a treatment on this exhibition, see also Fee 2011, 15–17 and Moure Cecchini 2021, 257–67, esp. 263–67.

[6] It should be noted that Kann consigned a significant portion of his antiquities, medieval objects, and Old Masters to auction in New York in 1927 (American Art Association 1927, Pts. 1-2). Felliciano suggests that he did this in order to accommodate nineteenth-century and modern artworks (Feliciano 1997, 111).

der bildenden Künste to Valentin, 14 Nov. 1936, cited in Petropoulos 2011, n.52)—was also a frequent associate of Stendahl during the war. The “Toltec figure” passed through this same network: consigned by Stendahl first to Valentin (Stendahl to Valentin, [undated, probably early 1943], SAGR, b1f10), prior to its exhibition at Worcester Art Gallery, and subsequently to Schempp in November 1943 (Stendahl to Schempp, 29 Nov. 1943, SAGR, b99f6), before entering Callery’s collection.

Just as the painting’s acquisition history resists complete reconstruction, the sculpture’s find-context remains unknown and its cultural attribution conflicted: the earlier consignment note to Valentin identifies the sculpture as a “Tarascan standing figure from Colima,” while Stendahl later reclassified it as a “Toltec figure from Cholula”—two decidedly distinct geographic and cultural designations. Documentation from the time of its entry into Stendahl’s stock via Mexican dealer–collector Guillermo Echániz further demonstrates that this uncertainty about the object’s identification and provenience was present from the outset: Stendahl corrected the designation in Echániz’ typed note from “Tarascan” to “Toltec,” while maintaining that it was from “Puebla” (Echániz and Stendahl, [first half of 1941], SAGR, b11f9) (fig. 4e).[7] Such inconsistencies were not unusual. Stendahl was still relatively new to pre-Hispanic art in the early 1940s, as noted above, and the archive contains recurrent provenance- and provenience-related lacunae, misattributions, and other shifting identifications. Nevertheless, the documented trajectory of the putative “Toltec figure”—its consignments and exhibition histories—strongly suggests that Stendahl was referring to the same object in the subsequent documents. The connection to Echániz, moreover, is particularly significant given his role as a supplier and agent in the circulation of Mexican antiquities, including objects that had been illicitly excavated and illegally exported (Phillips Quintanilla, forthcoming). Indeed, what the archival record withholds, in this case, is not the object’s movement, but its origin: no findspot, no archaeological context. The painting and the figurine, in other words, followed strikingly parallel paths, moving between the

[7] The number 73, written in graphite in the left margin of the Stendahl Inventory page (fig. 4a), corresponds to that found on the Echániz-typed document (fig. 4e) (Phillips Quintanilla, pers. comm. 29 Aug. 2026); on the date of the document/shipment, see Turner and Phillips Quintanilla 2023, 11. The note indicates that Stendahl procured the object from Echániz for just $8 and it was sold to Callery for $150, showing that Stendahl and Schempp applied a significant markup in the range of 1,775%. The Arensbergs updated the attribution of their similar object (fig. 4b) to “Tarascan - Nayarit” (Catalogue card for “Red Clay Man” figure, in WLA, box 25, folder 1). This is also erroneous: the term “Tarascan” specifically applies to the Late Postclassic culture centered in Lake Patzcuaro, Michoacan (Michael Mathiowetz, pers. comm., 29 Apr. 2026).

same hands—Callery, Stendahl, Schempp, Valentin—even as the gaps in their histories obscure different moments in their provenance histories.

Shared Rooms, Shared Worlds

In 1950, Stendahl sold the Léger painting to Michiganders Harry and Lydia Winston, an acquisition that also catalyzed the Winstons’ efforts to assemble a prominent collection of pre-Hispanic art alongside modern European painting. A letter from Winston’s representative makes clear how this shift unfolded: Lydia Winston initially focused on acquiring paintings, but having witnessed such pairings in the Stendahl home (see, for example, fig. 2), she was convinced to pursue building a collection of pre-Hispanic art in earnest ([illegible sender] to Stendahl, 17 Apr. 1950, SAGR, b100f25):

> Mrs. Winston has been giving serious consideration to the acquisition of the Leger [*sic*] and Gleizes which she saw in your home, as well as a couple of pre-Columbians. The Leger [*sic*] is an early large oil which is hung in the dining room over the side-board [...] the seated pre-Columbian figure which you characterized as the “God of Music”. [...]
>
> She is just starting out on a collection of pre-Columbians which we hope will develop into a large and recognized collection.”

By the 1960s, the Winstons’ home (fig. 5) vividly embodied this dialogic approach with ancient American objects and twentieth-century European art—observe our *La femme au fauteuil* on the far back wall—sharing the same space. The receipt for the purchase includes, among other paintings by Albert Gleizes and Marsden Hartley, a “Tarascan figure from Nayarit” and a stone figure from Costa Rica (Stendahl to Harry Winston, 2 Jun. 1950, SAGR, b100f25; Inv. Nos. 2790 and [CR]363, Inventory Book, SAGR, b97).

Fig. 5. Downstairs room in the Winstons’ house in Birmingham, Michigan, 1969. Lydia Winston Malbin Papers. Yale Collection of American Literature, Beinecke Rare Book and Manuscript Library. © 2026 Artists Rights Society (ARS), New York; © 2026 Giacomo Balla / Artists Rights Society (ARS), New York; © 2026 Calder Foundation, New York / Artists Rights Society (ARS), New York; © 2026 Carlo Carra / Artists Rights Society (ARS), New York; © 2026 Pietro Consagra / Artists Rights Society (ARS), New York; © 2026 Eduardo Paolozzi / Artists Rights Society (ARS), New York / DACS, London; © 2026 Antoine Pevsner / Artists Rights Society (ARS), New York / ADAGP, Paris; © 2026 Gino Severini / Artists Rights Society (ARS), New York / ADAGP, Paris.

In 1990, the painting was acquired at auction by the Swiss dealer and collector Ernst Beyeler (Sotheby’s 1990, lot 52; Fondation Beyeler, “La Femme au Fauteuil”), whom the *New York Times* eulogized as “Europe’s pre-eminent dealer in modern art” (Grimes 2010). Beyeler, too, had transacted with the Stendahls, when they traded him “Pre Col [pre-Columbian objects] for French paintings” as they expanded their operations to Europe in the late 1950s (Stendahl to Dammann, 20 Mar. 1959, SAGR, b105f6; see also King et al., forthcoming and King and P. Quintanilla in this volume). The painting’s return to Europe therefore exemplifies the continued transatlantic circulation of modern and pre-Hispanic art within intertwined markets throughout

the twentieth century.

Conclusion

We thus arrive full circle at the mid-century moment when dealers like Stendahl and Schempp did more than simply facilitate transactions; they actively shaped markets, collecting practices, and broader cultural narratives through which these objects were interpreted, valued, and circulated. Their entwined histories bring into sharp focus both the fluidity with which the dealers moved between the ancient and the modern, treating them as part of a single continuum in which diverse objects could rendezvous and interact. They also illustrate the ethical complexities of the dealers’ enterprise: their complicity in the looting and commodification of cultural heritage in colonial and postcolonial contexts, as well as their involvement in the transatlantic art trade during and after WWII. Considered together, the objects’ paths underscore the value of rethinking the traditional boundaries that have structured provenance research to date, shifting toward a more “comparative, entangled and global history” approach (Gaudenzi and Swenson 2017, 497; see also Peters 2023), one that moves beyond linear chains of ownership to *interconnected* histories of taste, commerce, and dispossession. The rendezvous of these objects, and the people who were involved in their movement, shows not only how they shaped one another’s reception, but, more broadly, how the markets for ancient and modern were—and remain—woven tightly together.

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